

The CW 10 Open Workshop

by Michael Balili

Workshop Roles

Moderator – guides the discussion

Author – receives critiques, answers questions

Reader – observes, suggests, questions, critiques

Non-negotiable: Everyone should have read the work before coming to the workshop. Everyone should also speak their mind during the workshop. It takes a village, people!

The entire workshop process consists of 30% of your grade for this class. The final draft & folio consist of 25% of your grade.

The Workshop Process

1. The moderator gives a short opening statement.
2. The moderator asks the author to give a short reading of their work. The author should find a short passage that the author thinks it's their best lines/paragraph/passage.
3. The moderator asks the readers: what is the objective situation of the text?
4. The objective situation answers these questions:
 - What physically happens in the story or poem or CNF?
 - What details are readers actually given (versus inferred)?
 - What can we know from what's presented, without assuming emotional or symbolic meanings?

The author is not dead. Or silent.

- The moderator can sometimes ask the author clarifying questions about the text.
- The author can discuss their project or intention or what they wanted to achieve.
- The author should listen carefully to the feedback without interrupting or explaining.
- The author should be open to the idea that their work might be read in ways they didn't intend—and that's okay.
- The author should jot down reactions: what feels useful, surprising, or even uncomfortable (in a good way).
- The author must trust that their classmates are engaging the work seriously & generously.
- They're not expected to agree with everything—but they should stay open & grateful for the effort.
- The author should not feel slighted when they receive harsh critiques. We are all in this together & we all want to raise each other's works.
- In line with this, the reader should be respectful & avoid being bitchy, sarcastic, condescending—in other words, the reader should avoid being toxic.
- The author should only respond when asked to avoid disruption in the flow of discussion. When the author has a question, they will raise their hand so the moderator can give them time to speak.

Meat – A workshop is all about attention. & the best form of attention is asking questions. The readers should ask:::

Questions About Meaning & Intent

- What do you think this piece is trying to say?
- What emotions did this piece evoke in you?
- What do you think the central idea or image is?
- Is there a moment that feels like the emotional or narrative core?

Questions About Structure & Flow

- How does the piece begin and end? Are those choices effective?
- Did the order of events, images, or stanzas feel intentional?
- Were there any moments where you felt lost or confused?
- Does the pacing feel right for the piece?

Questions About Language & Style

- Which lines or phrases stood out to you, and why?
- Are there places where the language feels especially vivid or original?
- Are there areas where the language could be tightened or clarified?
- Do the tone and voice remain consistent throughout?

Questions About Voice & Character (For Fiction/Nonfiction/Persona Poems)

- Is the narrator's or speaker's voice distinctive?
- Did the characters feel real or dimensional?
- Were there opportunities to deepen the interiority (thoughts, emotions)?
- Do you understand the speaker's or character's motivations?

Questions About Impact & Reader Experience

- What lingered with you after reading this?
- Was there a part that made you pause or reread?
- What questions did this piece leave you with?
- Did anything feel unresolved—in a good or confusing way?

Questions for Revision Suggestions

- What's one part that could be expanded?
- What's one part that could be cut or trimmed?
- Is there a line or moment that feels out of place?
- If the writer could revise only one thing, what would be most impactful?

After the workshop

- The author speaks and realigns their project from the comments they received from the workshop.
- The author can ask follow-up questions and clarifications.
- The author should reflect on feedback that was helpful to their project.
- Absolutely no crying.

The moderator wraps up and summarizes key points.

Everyone thanks the author for sharing vulnerable work.

We clap—to honor the writer's courage and the group's care.

It's a gesture of gratitude: for sharing, for listening, for risking something on the page.